

A Better Open Area

How the UCSC Open Area is used for academic and non-academic activities across different times of the day, and what factors influence students to choose the space for studying versus social interaction

Research Area: UCSC Open Area

Module: SCS 3312 – Research Methods

Group Number: 08

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Contents

1	Introduction	1
2	Research Problem	2
3	Research Objectives	3
4	Significance of the Study	4
5	Proposed Methodology	5
5.1	Quantitative Data Collection	5
5.1.1	Structured Observation	5
5.2	Qualitative Data Collection	6
5.2.1	Semi-Structured Interviews	6
6	Expected Outcomes	7
7	Feasibility	8
8	Conclusion	8

1 Introduction

Open study areas are one of the most important features of a university. But even though these spaces are mentioned as study areas, they are used for many other non-academic and recreational activities. Students use these spaces for studying, group discussions, social interaction, or relaxation depending on environmental conditions, social context, and time-related constraints. Hence these spaces act as informal learning environments.

Understanding how students utilize these spaces is important because it provides insight into understanding students behavior, effectiveness of the space according to the context it is used as, and the role of an informal learning environment within university life.

This study aims to investigate the patterns of usage within the UCSC open area and identify the factors that influence students' decisions to use the space for studying or social interaction.

Field Site

The selected field site for this study is the Open Area of the University of Colombo School of Computing. Observations will be conducted during multiple periods of the day (within operating hours of the university), including:

- Morning
- Midday
- Afternoon
- Evening

This will allow the group to identify changes in utilization patterns over time.

2 Research Problem

The UCSC open area is frequently occupied by students throughout the day. However the way students utilize this space changes throughout the day. While some students use this area for individual or group studying, others use it for casual discussions, social gatherings, club activities, or other recreational activities. Currently, there is a limited understanding on what causes these changes in behavior.

Without such understanding, it is difficult to evaluate the effectiveness of the open area as a shared academic environment.

Research Questions

1. How does the utilization of the UCSC open area vary across different times of the day?
2. What proportion of observed activities within the open area are academic versus non-academic?
3. What environmental and social factors influence students' decision to use the space for studying rather than social interaction?

3 Research Objectives

Main Objective

To investigate how the UCSC open area is utilized for academic and non-academic purposes and identify the factors influencing students' choice of activity within the space.

Specific Objectives

- To observe and categorize activities occurring within the UCSC open area.
- To identify temporal patterns in space utilization throughout the day.
- To compare the frequency of academic and non-academic activities.
- To identify environmental and social factors affecting students' use of the space.
- To understand student perceptions regarding the suitability of the open area for studying and social interaction.

4 Significance of the Study

This study is relevant because by understanding how students utilize the UCSC open area, the study may provide valuable insight under the following key points.

- the effectiveness of informal learning environments,
- behavioral patterns within shared student spaces,
- and factors that encourage or discourage academic engagement in open environments.

The findings may contribute to future improvements in campus space design, usage and student facility management.

5 Proposed Methodology

This study will be conducted in a mixed-method research approach using both qualitative and quantitative data collection methods.

5.1 Quantitative Data Collection

5.1.1 Structured Observation

The research group will conduct direct observations within the UCSC open area during different time periods across multiple days of the week(including weekends).The following data may be recorded:

- Number of students present
- Type of activity performed
 - Individual studying
 - Group studying
 - Casual discussion
 - Social interaction
 - Recreational activity
 - University club activity
- Group size
- Approximate session duration
- Occupancy level
- Noise level
- Temperature

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- Lighting conditions
 - Weather conditions
 - Time of observation

5.2 Qualitative Data Collection

5.2.1 Semi-Structured Interviews

Short interviews will be conducted with students using the open area.

Possible interview topics include:

- Reasons for choosing the space
- Preference for studying or social interaction
- Environmental factors influencing usage
- Perceived advantages and disadvantages of the space
- Suitability of the area for academic activities
- Suggested improvements to the space according to the activity done

Interview responses will be used to identify recurring themes and behavioral patterns.

6 Expected Outcomes

The study is expected to:

- identify dominant usage patterns within the UCSC open area,
- reveal how the space usage changes throughout the day,
- distinguish between academic and non-academic usage trends,
- and identify key factors influencing student behavior within the space.

The findings may help develop a better understanding of how informal campus spaces support both learning and social interaction.

7 Feasibility

The proposed study is feasible because:

- the field site is easily accessible,
- observations can be conducted without specialized equipment,
- the activities are directly observable,
- and the required data can be collected within the allocated time frame using simple research methods.

This study aligns with the assignment requirement of conducting a real-world mixed-method investigation grounded in observable behavior.

8 Conclusion

In this proposal, a mixed-method approach is suggested as an attempt to examine the use of the UCSC open area by students for both educational and non-educational purposes. With the help of structured observations and semi-structured interviews, it is possible to find out the temporal use of the space and factors affecting students' behavior there. This research is both practical and feasible.